

RAISING THE BAR Union home minister Amit Shah (centre) leads a road show, with Gujarat BJP chief C.R. Patil (left) and CM Bhupendra Patel by his side, in Gandhinagar Lok Sabha constituency, Apr. 18

Earlier that day, on April 18, riding a makeshift chariot atop a mini truck, the 59-year-old waved to supporters jostling on the roads under the scorching sun for a glimpse of their leader. "Raise your hands and take a pledge to vote for the *kamal* (lotus, the BJP symbol) before 10.30 am on May 7," he exhorted a gathering at Vejalpur, concluding his 10-hour-long road show, as hands shot up in unison. "Now I am relaxed," he said, "to campaign in other parts of the country and return here on the day of voting."

With over two million voters in this Lok Sabha constituency, Shah claims that his team has visited nearly every home at least once. The microscopic attention to detail and the presence of thousands of dedicated foot soldiers, combined with the natural appeal of the idea of voting for *aapdo manas* (our man/a Gujarati) as the prime minister, are key to Shah's confidence—so much so that he spent only one day holding road shows and rallies before filing his nomination papers.

A prestigious seat for the BJP, Gandhinagar was long held by party veteran Lal Krishna Advani, whom Shah replaced in 2019. In 1996, party patriarch Atal Bihari Vajpayee had also thrown his hat into the ring from Gandhinagar besides Lucknow, but chose to retain the latter after winning both. Having learnt the ropes in the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP), the student wing of the BJP's ideological fountainhead Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), Shah, in fact, had first gained prominence as Advani's campaign manager in the 1991 Lok Sabha election. But Shah brings a distinct advantage his predecessor lacked—he is a local. Shah's ancestral village Mansa falls in the Gandhinagar North assembly segment and he entered the Gujarat Vidhan Sabha from the erstwhile Sarkhej seat in 1997, representing it till its dissolution in the delimitation exercise of 2012. Subsequently, he was elected to the state assembly from Naranpura, where, too, he had a house. "As an ABVP activist, I used to draw the lotus symbol on the walls of Naranpura," he reminisced at the Vejalpur rally.

Of the seven assembly segments that make up the Gandhinagar Lok Sabha constituency, four—Naranpura, Vejalpur, Ghatlodia and Sabarmati—are predominantly urban and fall under Ahmedabad district. The remaining three—Gandhinagar North, Kalol and Sanand—cover several villages, which, too, are witnessing a rapid urbanisation. Gandhinagar, in fact, remains an exemplar of the BJP's development plank, with a number of big-ticket infrastructure projects concentrated here, unrivalled by any other urban agglomeration across the country. These include Modi's two pet projects—GIFT City, which is India's first and only International Financial Services Centre, and the Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel Sports Enclave in Motera, which also houses the world's largest cricket stadium named after him. In fact, during his speech at Vejalpur, Shah announced that hosting the 2036 Summer Olympics in Gandhinagar is a 'Modi ki Guarantee' even as India is competing with countries such as Germany, Italy, Canada, China and South Korea to host the world's biggest sporting event.

Opposite the sports enclave, massive concourses are under construction at the Sabarmati Multimodal Transport Hub—home to the terminal bullet train station in Gujarat. Based on Japan's Shinkansen, the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High Speed Rail (MAHSR) project is estimated to cost Rs 1.08 lakh crore and will reduce the rail travel time between the two terminal hubs from the current 5-7 hours to just over two hours. About 30 kilometres away, Sanand is being developed as an automobile, semiconductor and space manufacturing hub. It's here that the US chip-



SAFFRON STRONGHOLD

The BJP has never lost the Gandhinagar seat since 1989. Party veteran L.K. Advani won it six times; even former PM A.B. Vajpayee was victorious in 1996 but chose to resign and retain the Lucknow seat instead

